



Spitfire's original elliptical wing was retained for all but the last Seafires

◀ SUPERMARINE SEAFIRE

Date 1943 **Origin** UK

Wingspan 11.23m (36¾ft)

Length 9.62m (31½ft)

Top speed 630kph (391mph)

Engine 1,379.5kW (1,850hp)
Rolls-Royce Griffon VI V-12

The UK received a large number of carriers and carrier aircraft from the US, but there was a shortfall in the latter. This led to the modification of the Spitfire – the Mark V, to begin with – for shipborne operation.

Three-bladed constant-pitch propeller

▼ MITSUBISHI A6M ZERO

Date 1944 **Origin** Japan

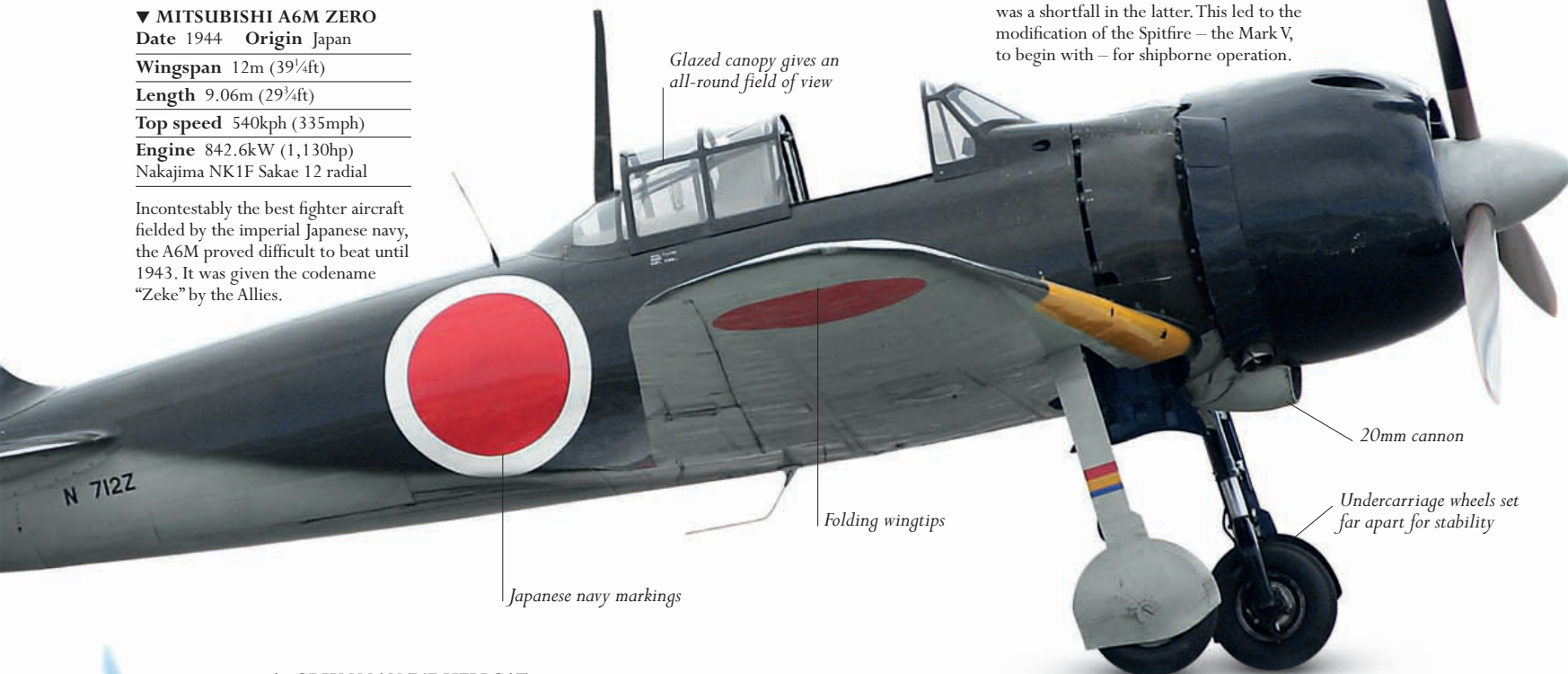
Wingspan 12m (39¾ft)

Length 9.06m (29¾ft)

Top speed 540kph (335mph)

Engine 842.6kW (1,130hp)
Nakajima NK1F Sakae 12 radial

Incontestably the best fighter aircraft fielded by the imperial Japanese navy, the A6M proved difficult to beat until 1943. It was given the codename "Zeke" by the Allies.



Glazed canopy gives an all-round field of view

Folding wingtips

Japanese navy markings

20mm cannon

Undercarriage wheels set far apart for stability

► GRUMMAN F6F HELLCAT

Date 1944 **Origin** US

Wingspan 13.06m (42¾ft)

Length 10.24m (33½ft)

Top speed 610kph (379mph)

Engine 1,640.5kW (2,200hp) Pratt & Whitney R-2800-10W Double Wasp radial

The Hellcat looked enough like the Wildcat to confuse the Japanese pilots it met, which was unfortunate for them as it was an entirely new design, with an extra 96.5kph (60mph) on its top speed and acceleration to match.



Pilot sat high in fuselage, protected by armour plate and bulletproof windscreen

Each wing housed three .5in machine-guns



Each wing housed two .5in machine-guns or two 20mm cannon

Wide-track undercarriage to aid stability during take-off and landing

◀ GRUMMAN F8F BEARCAT

Date 1945 **Origin** US

Wingspan 10.92m (35¾ft)

Length 8.61m (28¼ft)

Top speed 680kph (422mph)

Engine 1,789.6kW (2,400hp)
Pratt & Whitney R-2800-34W
Double Wasp radial

The last of the World War II "Cats", the F8F was 20 per cent lighter than the F6F Hellcat, and even with the same power plant (engine) climbed 30 per cent faster and had an extra 64.3kph (40mph) on its top speed.



Cockpit set well back to improve pilot's field of view

US Navy markings

► Vought F4U CORSAIR

Date 1942 **Origin** US

Wingspan 12.5m (41ft)

Length 10.1m (33ft)

Top speed 670kph (416mph)

Engine 1,491.3kW (2,000hp) Pratt & Whitney R-2800-8 radial

The Corsair was undoubtedly the most capable carrier-based fighter aircraft of World War II, and also gave very good service as a fighter-bomber. A total of 12,571 were produced between 1942 and 1953.